

# Lesson 10:

## Linear Coherence of a Surah: Ya-sin, Al-Fatihah, Al-Baqarah, Al-Kahf

### Lesson 10: Linear Coherence of a Surah: Ya-sin, Al-Fatihah, Al-Baqarah, Al-Kahf

The coherence of an entire surah can be studied in three ways: linear, anchor and structural. This section focuses on the linear coherence of some surahs where one idea progressively leads to another.

#### Case Study: Surah Ya-Sin (1-12)

| Section | Ayah                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
|---------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| A       | يس ﴿١﴾ وَالْقُرْآنِ الْحَكِيمِ ﴿٢﴾ إِنَّكَ لَمِنَ الْمُرْسَلِينَ ﴿٣﴾ عَلَى صِرَاطٍ مُسْتَقِيمٍ ﴿٤﴾ تَنْزِيلَ الْعَزِيزِ الرَّحِيمِ ﴿٥﴾                                                                          |
| B       | لِتُنذِرَ قَوْمًا مَّا أُنذِرَ آبَاؤُهُمْ فَهُمْ غَافِلُونَ ﴿٦﴾                                                                                                                                                 |
| C       | لَقَدْ حَقَّ الْقَوْلُ عَلَى أَكْثَرِهِمْ فَهُمْ لَا يُؤْمِنُونَ ﴿٧﴾                                                                                                                                            |
| D       | إِنَّا جَعَلْنَا فِي أَعْنَاقِهِمْ أَغْلَالًا فَهِيَ إِلَى الْأَذْقَانِ فَهُمْ مُقْمَحُونَ ﴿٨﴾ وَجَعَلْنَا مِنْ بَيْنِ أَيْدِيهِمْ سَدًّا وَمِنْ خَلْفِهِمْ سَدًّا فَأَعْشَيْنَاهُمْ فَهُمْ لَا يُبْصِرُونَ ﴿٩﴾ |
| C       | وَسَوَاءٌ عَلَيْهِمْ أُنذِرْتَهُمْ أَمْ لَمْ تُنذِرْهُمْ لَا يُؤْمِنُونَ ﴿١٠﴾                                                                                                                                   |
| B       | إِنَّمَا تُنذِرُ مَنِ اتَّبَعَ الذِّكْرَ وَخَشِيَ الرَّحْمَنَ الْغَيْبَ ۖ فَبَشِّرْهُ بِمَغْفِرَةٍ وَأَجْرٍ كَرِيمٍ ﴿١١﴾                                                                                        |
| A       | إِنَّا نَحْنُ نُحْيِي الْمَوْتَى وَنَكْتُبُ مَا قَدَّمُوا وَآثَرَهُمْ ۚ وَكُلَّ شَيْءٍ أَحْصَيْنَاهُ فِي إِمَامٍ مُبِينٍ ﴿١٢﴾                                                                                   |

| Section | Translation                                                                                                                                                                                 |
|---------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1A      | Ya, Seen. (1) By the wise Quran. (2) Indeed you, [O Muhammad], are from among the messengers, (3) On a straight path. (4) [This is] a revelation of the Exalted in Might, the Merciful, (5) |
| 1B      | That you may warn a people whose forefathers were not warned, so they are unaware. (6)                                                                                                      |

|    |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
|----|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1C | Already the word has come into effect upon most of them, so they do not believe. ( <u>7</u> )                                                                                                                                                  |
| 1D | Indeed, We have put shackles on their necks, and they are to their chins, so they are with heads [kept] aloft. ( <u>8</u> ) And We have put before them a barrier and behind them a barrier and covered them, so they do not see. ( <u>9</u> ) |
| 1C | And it is all the same for them whether you warn them or do not warn them - they will not believe. ( <u>10</u> )                                                                                                                               |
| 1B | You can only warn one who follows the message and fears the Most Merciful unseen. So give him good tidings of forgiveness and noble reward. ( <u>11</u> )                                                                                      |
| 1A | Indeed, it is We who bring the dead to life and record what they have put forth and what they left behind, and all things We have enumerated in a clear register. ( <u>12</u> )                                                                |

### Connection

Associations are drawn between ayat with similar subject matter. (Note: “Top” refers to the top ayah/ayat in the symmetry, while “Bottom” refers to the bottom ayah/ayat in the symmetry.)

### Section A

- *Top*: Revelation
- *Bottom*: All records written down

### Section B

- *Top*: Revelation sent so that you may warn
- *Bottom*: Only those fearful of Allah can be warned

### Section C

- *Top*: They don’t believe
- *Bottom*: Whether warned or not, they will not believe

### Section D

- They are blinded from all sides.
- There are three roads to guidance: revelation, history, and what is around you. Guidance from above is revelation, guidance from behind is history, and guidance from around, is whatever surrounds you. Allah mentions that these people described in the ayat are blinded to this guidance and therefore can’t see properly.

## Symmetry/Ring Composition Within Passages

### Case Study: Surah Al-Baqarah (40-122)

|         |  |  |  |  |  |  |  |                                                                               |
|---------|--|--|--|--|--|--|--|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 40-46   |  |  |  |  |  |  |  | ISRAELITES! BE GRATEFUL AND FEARFUL!                                          |
| 48-50   |  |  |  |  |  |  |  | ESCAPE FROM THE PHAROAH                                                       |
| 51-56   |  |  |  |  |  |  |  | WORSHIP OF THE CALF                                                           |
| 55-74   |  |  |  |  |  |  |  | VIOLATION OF COVENANT (WRONGED YOURSELVES, HEARTS TO STONE)                   |
|         |  |  |  |  |  |  |  | YOUR HEARTS TURNED TO STONE, EVEN STONES FALL                                 |
| 75-91   |  |  |  |  |  |  |  | THEY WON'T BELIEVE NEW COVENANT BECAUSE THEY VIOLATED THEIR OWN               |
| 92-93   |  |  |  |  |  |  |  | WORSHIP OF THE CALF                                                           |
| 94-96   |  |  |  |  |  |  |  | WISH TO ESCAPE DEATH AT ALL COST                                              |
| 97-103  |  |  |  |  |  |  |  | ANIMOSITY TO ANGELS, ALLEGIANCE TO DEVILS                                     |
| 104-106 |  |  |  |  |  |  |  | MOCKERY OF AND SKEPTICISM ABOUT NEW REVELATION OUT OF JEALOUSY, R U HOPEFUL?  |
| 106-107 |  |  |  |  |  |  |  | ALLAH HAS POWER OVER ALL THINGS                                               |
| 108-110 |  |  |  |  |  |  |  | DON'T DISRESPECT MESSENGER, SUBMIT, BE HUMBLE, SEEK OTHER WORLDLY REWARD      |
| 111     |  |  |  |  |  |  |  | ONLY CHISTIANS AND JEWS ENTER HEAVEN?                                         |
| 112     |  |  |  |  |  |  |  | IN FACT, THOSE WHO SUBMIT THEIR FACE BEFORE GOD!                              |
| 113     |  |  |  |  |  |  |  | JEWS AND CHRISTIANS INVALIDATE EACH OTHER                                     |
| 114     |  |  |  |  |  |  |  | THE WORST PEOPLE DISRESPECT THE MASJIDS CORRUPTING THEM                       |
| 115-117 |  |  |  |  |  |  |  | ALLAH HAS NO SON, OWNS EAST AND WEST, CREATED EVERYTHING                      |
| 118-121 |  |  |  |  |  |  |  | SKEPTICISM ABOUT REVELATION OUT OF IGNORANCE, STUBORNNESS, THERE IS SOME HOPE |
| 122     |  |  |  |  |  |  |  | ISRAELITES! BE GRATEFUL AND FEARFUL                                           |

### Linear Coherence of an Entire Surah

This can be studied in three ways:

- Linear (how A leads to B, B leads to C, etc)
- Anchors
- Structural

### **Case Study: Surah Al-Fatihah**

Ayat 1-3: Knowledge (learn something about Allah)

Ayah 4: Action (now you are ready to take action)

Ayat 5-6 : The path of knowledge and action (ask for guidance along the straight path)

Not the path of knowledge without action

Nor the path of action without knowledge

### **Case Study: Surah Al-Baqarah**

Discussions:

- A. Faith, disbelief and hypocrisy (comes out by tests)
- B. Story of Adam PBUH (Father) (Tested) (Didn't succeed but repented)
- C. Children of Israel (Children)(Tested) (Didn't succeed, didn't repent)
- D. Ibrahim (Father) (Tested) (Succeeded and repented)
- E. Change of Qiblah (Jerusalem to Mecca) (Major test)
- F. We are a New Ummah (Children) (Tested) (Succeed or Fail, we don't know)
- G. Laws of Islam (15 of them) (Will put you to the test) (Greed is the hardest test)
- H. Guidance on greed (how to deal with spending, unacceptable ribah, acceptable business)
- I. Prayer for help against tests

### **Connections:**

A & I: Faith, disbelief, and hypocrisy

B & H: Story of Greed

C & G: Don't mess up your laws like the Israelites

E: Change of Qiblah, point where everything changed

### **Case Study: Surah Al-Kahf**

Discussions:

Ayat 1-8 The book stands firm to warn against great trials (Sermon)

Ayat 9-26 Youth of the cave (Divine intervention and apparent relief) (Story)

Ayat 27-31 Stand by the weak companions as they are with Allah! (Sermon)

Ayat 32-44 Story of the gardener and his neighbor (Divine intervention and apparent distress) (Story)

Ayat 45-59 Nothing in life is permanent except your deeds and the afterlife (Sermon)

Ayat 60-82 Musa PBUH's three-stop journey (Story) Ship, boy, and wall (Not visible divine intervention and apparent distress)

Ayat 83-99 Dhul Qarnain's three-stop journey (Not visible intervention and apparent Relief), West to do justice, East leaves alone, and wall

Ayat 100-110 The real punishment for bad people and the real reward for good people is in the afterlife. Words of Allah are an endless ocean (Sermon)